BEYOND LOVE: WHY PRECISE NUTRITION AND PAEDIATRIC CARE SHAPE YOUR PET'S LIFETIME HEALTH

Bringing home a new puppy or kitten is a joyous milestone. As pet owners, our first instinct is to shower our pets with love, warmth, and comfort. However, when it comes to their health and daily feeding, love alone is not enough to sustain their rapid physical and cognitive development.

In India, where packaged pet food adoption remains at less than 15%, most puppies and kittens are raised primarily on home-cooked meals. While these meals are prepared with the utmost affection, scientific research reveals a critical gap: up to 95% of home-cooked meals are nutritionally incomplete for pets[1]. While a standard home-cooked bowl of chicken and rice may seem like a wholesome choice, it typically provides only 10 to 15 essential nutrients in the right balance[2] – whereas puppies[3] and kittens[4] need 35+ essential nutrients to support healthy growth and development.



The Critical Growth Window

The first year of a pet's life represents a period of extraordinary growth, and their nutritional requirements look vastly different from those of human infants or adult pets.

Key milestones during this critical window include:

Brain Development: Nearly 80% of a pet's brain development happens within the first 4 months of life. To support this rapid cognitive growth, precise levels of Omega-3 Fatty Acid (DHA) is absolutely essential.

Immune System Support: During **first 4-12 weeks age,** maternal antibodies provided through "Coloustrum" naturally decline and fall even below the protective threshold making puppies & kittens highly vulnerable to acquiring the infection. Science-backed nutrients like **Vitamin C, Vitamin E, Lutein,** and **Taurine** act as an antioxidant and along with **L-arginine & Beta-carotene** support to bolster their developing natural defences and helps to bridge this **"Immunity-Gap".** Puppies and kittens develop nearly **80% of their immune system** in their first year. Nutrients like **Beta-glucans** help to enhance the antibody production to ensure greater immune response.



Digestive Health: A pet's gut does far more than digest food; a significant portion of their immune system is linked to the digestive tract. Building a healthy gut environment early in life prevents chronic digestive sensitivities down the road.

Bridging the Gap: The Paediatric Approach

Recognizing the critical need for early-life awareness, Royal Canin has launched a nationwide 360-degree campaign with a thoughtful provocation: *"Love is the #1 ingredient, but your puppies & kitten need 35+ nutrients more."* The campaign urges pet owners to transition from reactive care to proactive, science-backed prevention.

To support this journey, Royal Canin has partnered with veterinary professionals through the **Paediatric Veterinary Care Program.** This initiative encourages new pet owners to schedule early vet visits by offering a free or discounted first consultation. During these visits, veterinarians employ structured paediatric protocols—such as growth charts, Body Condition Scoring (BCS), Muscle Condition Scoring (MCS)—to monitor growth, check weight, administer timely vaccinations, and recommend tailored diets.

Investing in science-backed precise nutrition and professional guidance during the pets' start of life stage is the greatest act of care we can offer, ensuring our companions grow into healthy, thriving partners for life.

— By Dr. Vishal Dangle,
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1. (Stockman J, 2003)
2. (disclaimer.findroyalcanin.com, n.d.)
3. (ROYAL CANIN®, n.d.)
4. (ROYAL CANIN®, n.d.)